

BURNING DISCONTENT
Angry Punjab farmers burn Mann's effigy in Amritsar, Jan. 3

AFP

the Guru Granth Sahib to police stations as a shield cannot be called 'waris' of Punjab and Punjabiyat in any way." Mann, who was on a tour of Gujarat and Maharashtra, didn't consider the Ajnala incident serious enough for him to cancel his trip and return to the state. Instead, speaking in Mumbai, he asserted: "Law and order is under control in Punjab. Ours is a peaceful state."

FLAILING LAW AND ORDER

The ground reality, though, belies any such assertion. Since early January, the Quami Insaf Morcha, a radical group led by Gurcharan Singh Hawara (foster father of Babbar Khalsa International chief Jagtar Singh Hawara, who had been convicted for assassinating former Punjab CM Beant Singh), has been seeking the release of 22 convicted terrorists, including his son, collectively called 'Bandi Singhs' (Sikh prisoners). The protesters have blocked the highway connecting capital Chandigarh with satellite town Mohali since the first week of January. In early February, 30 policemen were injured when these protesters tried to storm Mann's residence in Chandigarh, but it took a while for the police to file an FIR and chargesheet the perpetrators.

Among AAP's promises was also one that said action would be taken on the demands of another morcha, the Bargari Insaf Morcha. Its members had been sitting on an indefinite dharna at the Behbal Kalan site since December 16, 2021, along with family members of two devouts killed in police firing while protesting the sacrilege of the Guru Granth Sahib in Bargari in 2015. Last month, an AAP MLA, Kunwar Vijay Pratap Singh, a former IG of police, quit as chairman of the Government Assurances Committee of the Vidhan Sabha probing the sacrilege cases when the home secretary refused to share the final report of the Special Investigation Team constituted for the cases. More recently, the morcha activists blocked the Bathinda-Amritsar highway for an indefinite period.

Coincidentally, however, soon after the Ajnala police station incident, the AAP government announced that the SIT had indicted the then SAD chief minister Parkash Singh Badal and his son Sukhbir Singh Badal in addition to half a dozen senior policemen for the 2015 Behbal Kalan and Kotkapura police firing incidents and the sacrilege that preceded it. "We stand by the promise of ensuring justice," Mann said. "Whether a minister or his aide, law is one for all. Truth can never be hidden." While the morcha was planning to hold a thanksgiving rally on March 5, SAD general secretary Parambans Singh Romana lashed out at Mann saying, "CM Bhagwant Mann should devote his energies to controlling the law and order situation in the state. We have witnessed a police station being attacked in Ajnala, gangsters are running crime syndicates from jails and gangsters outside are executing rivals in prisons. The entire state is in a severe crisis. Instead of tackling these burning issues, the AAP government is hell-bent on playing politics with the sacrilege issue."

The real problem is that the moderate space has been shrinking in Punjab ever since the SAD and Congress in the past five years began losing traction among the younger aspirational generation of Sikhs who were disillusioned by the lack of employment opportunities, rampant corruption and fell prey to easily available drugs. The weakening of the Badals and the fragmentation of the SAD saw the party steadily lose its panthic base and hold over Sikh religious